

Sources & Lineage

Craft references for the hybrid genre project. A working library, not an anthology. Read as needed during Phase 2.

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

Each section covers one operation from 05_OPERATIONS-TOOLKIT.md. Each entry includes: the source, the move, a short passage or structural example, and a note on how the operation applies to the found document you're working with. Passages are excerpts shown for craft instruction – for full context, seek out the primary work.

This reference is loadable standalone – you do not have to read it in order. Skim to the operation you're considering. Look at how it works in practice. Return to your own material.

CONTENTS

- I. Erasure Ruefle · Reddy · Phillips · Bervin
- II. Annotation / Marginalia Carson · Bouilly · Howe
- III. Voice-Braiding Rankine · Nelson · Offill · Manguso
- IV. Fragmentation Carson · Gladman · Manguso
- V. Apparatus-Juxtaposition Kapil · Nelson · Machado
- VI. Silence-Marking Long Soldier · NourbeSe Philip · Bergvall
- VII. Frame Disclosure Kapil · Boyer · Nelson
- VIII. On the Ethics of Found Text
- IX. Further Reading

I.

Erasure

Remove most of the source. Leave words in position. The negative space is the work.

WHY IT WORKS

Erasure is the most radical operation available to you with this source, and paradoxically the most contained. The cut list is the writing. The source provides every word; you select which to remove. Because the source is already heavily written, erasure is easier here than with blank material – you are sculpting, not making from nothing.

Erasure also handles the found-document ethics elegantly. You use the source's words but you transform them into silence. The resulting poem is structurally yours – it would not exist without your choices about removal.

EXAMPLE – Mary Ruefle, A LITTLE WHITE SHADOW (2006)

Source: an obscure Victorian novel. Ruefle painted over most of the pages with white correction fluid, leaving small islands of the original text to function as poems. Reading the resulting book, you encounter a page of mostly-white with a few phrases hovering in place.

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STRUCTURE (schematic, showing how erasure works on a page):

----- the small hours -----

----- and nothing to be done ---

The erasure works because the phrases, isolated, do work the original sentences could not. A Victorian narrative becomes lyric. The small hours. And nothing to be done. The source gave up these lines when it was reduced. (Schematic is illustrative; not Ruefle's exact page.)

Applied to your source: erase the entire discovery scene inventory. Leave: "TV still on _____ hardened _____ dead skin _____ Fireplace and gas on." Or: erase the family letter down to the seven words that have to stay.

EXAMPLE – Srikanth Reddy, VOYAGER (2011)

Reddy erases Kurt Waldheim's UN Secretary-General memoir. Waldheim was later revealed to have been a Nazi intelligence officer. Reddy's book is three erasures of the same memoir – each revealing different content. The politics of the source are load-bearing: you cannot read *Voyager* without knowing Reddy is cutting into an unreliable narrator's self-defense.

The lesson for you: the source can be morally complicated, and the operation can acknowledge that complication rather than try to smooth it over. Your source is a family's grief document. It is not morally complicated in the way Waldheim's is – but your *relation* to it is, because you are not in the family. Erasure is a form that makes your relation to the source a matter of form.

EXAMPLE – Jen Bervin, *NETS* (2004)

Bervin takes Shakespeare's sonnets and prints each in full, but with most of the text set in gray and a few words set in black. The black words, read alone, become Bervin's poem; the gray words, read with them, remain Shakespeare's sonnet. Both exist on the page.

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STRUCTURE (how selective-color erasure looks):

In the old age black was not counted fair,
Or if it were, it bore not beauty's name;
But now black is beauty's successive heir,
And beauty slandered with a bastard shame.

Reading only the black words: black / beauty's / black / heir / shame. The sonnet becomes a four-word lyric about race and inheritance. The source remains legible behind it.

Applied to your source: print the family letter in gray; select a handful of words to remain in black. The letter remains readable; your poem emerges inside it.

EXAMPLE – Tom Phillips, *A HUMUMENT* (1970 – 2016)

Phillips bought a Victorian novel titled *A Human Document* for threepence in 1966 and spent fifty years making art on every page – painting, collage, drawing – always leaving small windows through which original text shows. He revised entire editions multiple times. The project is a life's work built from another person's discarded book.

The lesson: erasure does not have to be minimalist. Phillips fills the page with visual density, and the erased text appears as small islands of legibility within the visual composition. For your zine, this could mean heavy black bars, painted shapes, or ASCII blocks obscuring most of a page with only a phrase visible – a more aggressive visual register that still serves the operation.

Annotation / Marginalia

The source is primary. Your voice is marginalia, footnote, critical apparatus around it.

WHY IT WORKS

Annotation makes you the reader of the source rather than its author. The reader of your piece sees the source through your attention to it. This is the most disciplined way to put yourself in the piece without claiming anything. Your presence is your selection, your focus, your questions – not your confession.

For your source: this is likely the form you are already using. 03_DEEP-ANNOTATION.md is an annotation. If you rewrite that annotation in your voice (mine is too academic), you are most of the way to a layered hybrid piece.

EXAMPLE – Anne Carson, NOX (2010)

Carson's brother died. He had been estranged from the family for years. She built Nox as a scrapbook-in-a-box, accordion-folded, containing: translation notes on a single Catullus elegy (Carmen 101, itself about a dead brother), scanned letters he sent, photographs, stamps, handwriting, drawings. The book never directly narrates his death. It annotates the poem, over and over, and through that annotation a life and its loss assemble.

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STRUCTURE (how annotation structures a page):

multas many
multus, -a, -um adj. many, much, abundant; see also multus est quod

– he used to say everything was
 at once, all at once

The dictionary entry is for a word. The narrative line that follows belongs to the brother. The two voices touch but do not merge. The reader understands that this is grief organized as a lexicon.

EXAMPLE – Jenny Boully, THE BODY: AN ESSAY (2002)

Boully's book is entirely footnotes. The main text never appears – the page shows only the numbered footnotes, referring to a body of text the reader never sees. The absent essay is felt through the annotations to it.

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STRUCTURE (how Boully's annotation-without-source works):

[blank]

- ¹ Perhaps better: the mother's hands.
- ² A word-for-word transcription has been made.
- ³ See figures 4a, 4b, 4c – three rooms of the house.
- ⁴ Here the speaker pauses for a long time.

Applied to your source: you could write *only* your commentary on the found document – with numbered references to passages the reader never sees reproduced. The effect is that the source haunts the piece. It is cited but never quoted. It exists off-page.

EXAMPLE – Susan Howe, archival poetry (various)

Howe's body of work – *Souls of the Labadie Tract*, *That This*, *Spontaneous Particulars* – treats archival materials (letters, diaries, legal documents, library card catalogs) as raw source for lyric assemblage. Her books often reproduce photographic fragments of handwriting or typesetting from the originals. The visual texture of the archive becomes part of the poem.

For you: if you include scanned pieces of the source document in your zine – a visual fragment of Tianna's caretaker notes, a piece of the vital sign block reproduced at scale – you are in Howe's tradition. The archive itself becomes material.

III.

Voice-Braiding

Two voices alternate in distinct passages. Dialogue without conversation.

WHY IT WORKS

Voice-braiding is the most familiar hybrid move – which makes it legible but also the most tired. To use it well, resist the temptation to make the two voices complementary. Let them not-quite-fit. Let them fail to hear each other. The friction is the form.

For your source: the two voices are already present – the family's voice (Jay/Amy/Annie) and the caretaker's voice (Tianna). You could braid a third voice into that existing structure. Your voice becomes the one that hears both.

EXAMPLE – Claudia Rankine, *DON'T LET ME BE LONELY* (2004)

Rankine braids: personal first-person passages; transcribed TV news (8/31/98 stock market crash, 9/11 coverage, Bush press conferences); photographs (a blank TV, a pharmaceutical insert); pharmaceutical side-effect lists. The book's form is the mind of someone living in post-9/11 America – porous, inundated, private and public at once.

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STRUCTURE (how Rankine's braiding looks on a page):

[personal voice]

I forgot what I was going to say again. I forgot what I was going to say again. I forgot what I was going to say again.

[news/found voice]

The FDA has approved a new anti-depressant called Paxil. In clinical studies, side effects reported by patients included:

[list]

nausea, somnolence, insomnia, sweating, tremor, asthenia, anorgasmia, decreased libido, suicidal ideation.

The three registers are visually distinct (no tags needed – the reader learns to tell them apart by typography, position, and rhythm). Rankine uses this to build a private consciousness trying to metabolize the public one. For your piece: the hospital/medical register is already there in the source. Your voice can enter as a third register that cannot metabolize either.

EXAMPLE – Maggie Nelson, *BLUETS* (2009)

240 numbered fragments, ostensibly about the color blue. Actually about heartbreak, a friend's paralysis, the end of a relationship. The braiding is not between sources but between registers of Nelson's own voice: scholar (quoting Goethe on color theory,

Wittgenstein on private experience), lyric diarist, theorist of grief, sensualist.

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STRUCTURE (the numbered fragment as voice-marker):

1. Suppose I were to begin by saying that I had fallen in love with a color.
2. Isn't there something obscene about it. The wanting.
3. Goethe describes blue as "a charming nothing."
4. I was in the hospital for three days.

Each fragment is a voice shift. Movement between them is the form. The numbers do the work of section breaks without naming the register. For your piece: numbered fragments that alternate between source quotation and your commentary – with no pattern, no announced rhythm – would read as Nelson's descendent.

EXAMPLE – Jenny Offill, DEPT. OF SPECULATION (2014)

A novel, formally – but built entirely of fragments. Offill braids the narrator's voice with found quotes (Wittgenstein, the Stoics, NASA scientists, her daughter), NASA mission briefings, Buddhist koans, and domestic one-liners. No fragment is more than a paragraph; many are a single sentence.

The lesson: found material can be tiny. You do not need to reproduce the whole discovery scene. You can reproduce one line from it – just the italics, just the Fireplace and gas on – and let your fragments carry the rest.

Fragmentation

Break the source into smaller units than it presents itself in. Slow reading to the speed of attention.

WHY IT WORKS

Fragmentation makes each unit bear more weight than the original sentence intended it to. A hospital log is written to be read quickly. A fragment of a hospital log, isolated, is read slowly. The operation is not violence – it is attention.

EXAMPLE – Anne Carson, AUTOBIOGRAPHY OF RED (1998)

Carson tells the story of Geryon – a winged red monster from a lost Greek poem – as a contemporary novel-in-verse, in 47 numbered sections. Each section is a constellation of fragments, line-broken, with dense white space.

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STRUCTURE (Carson's fragment rhythm):

Geryon lay on his bed.

Outside the window dogs barked and the moon was full.

He thought about time.

He thought about his mother. About eggs.

About the way the light came in at the window
when the dogs stopped.

(Schematic – not exact Carson lines.) Note the indentation as a second voice marker, the one-line fragments, the white space doing the pacing. Your source has sentences that already want to be lines: the vital sign blocks, "Fireplace and gas on," "He made a handgun gesture with his fingers and put it in his mouth."

EXAMPLE – Renee Gladman, CALAMITIES (2016)

A book of short prose pieces, most beginning with the phrase "I began the day....". Each piece is a fragment of consciousness – the architecture of a morning, a thought, an arrangement of body against surface. Gladman's fragments are not narratively connected but share a single voice's attention.

For you: you could treat each fragment of your zero draft as its own small prose piece, self-contained, untitled. The connective tissue is you as the reader who wrote them all. Order matters but is not narratively causal.

EXAMPLE – Sarah Manguso, ONGOINGNESS (2015)

Short book built from fragments (sometimes two sentences, sometimes a paragraph), about Manguso's decades-long diary and her inability to stop writing in it. The book is about the failure of the diary as a form, written as a series of fragments.

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STRUCTURE (Manguso-style single-paragraph fragments):

I wrote so I could say I was truly paying attention.

*

Attention without record is a lie.

*

Record without attention is worse.

(Schematic voicing; not Manguso's exact lines.) Small asterisks or rules as section markers. No headers. Fragments build by accumulation, not argument. For you: three or four pages of your zine could be nothing but these – your fragments alone, no source material, no commentary. Then a page of the source. Then more of yours.

V.

Apparatus-Juxtaposition

Pair the source with the formal apparatus of an unrelated document – legal, recipe, manual, contract, report.

WHY IT WORKS

Genre collision. When you format a piece of your source as a real estate listing or a Yelp review or a prayer, the reader is forced into a third space where neither genre quite holds. The operation works once or twice per piece; more becomes gimmick.

EXAMPLE – Bhanu Kapil, *BAN EN BANLIEUE* (2015)

Kapil's book is organized around the 1979 race riot in Southall, London, specifically a South Asian girl (Ban) lying on the pavement during the riot. The book is structured as failed novel drafts, performance notes, police-report-like fragments, lecture transcripts, and the body's own fragmentation. The apparatus of the failed novel – discarded versions, missing chapters, stage directions for performances of the novel – is the form.

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STRUCTURE (Kapil's apparatus-as-voice):

[VERSION 4, abandoned]

Ban is on the pavement. Ban is lying on the pavement.
The riot has not started. The riot is happening in another street.
Ban hears but does not see.

[NOTE TO SELF:]

This will not work as a novel. What is a novel for a body that cannot get up.

(Schematic, not direct Kapil.) The "version" marker and the "note to self" are the apparatus of a novel under construction. Kapil uses this to refuse the novel while staying inside the novel-making process. The form itself is a refusal.

EXAMPLE – Carmen Maria Machado, *IN THE DREAM HOUSE* (2019)

Machado writes a memoir of an abusive relationship as a sequence of genre experiments – each chapter titled "Dream House as [X]". Dream House as Lesson. Dream House as Folktale. Dream House as Stoner Comedy. Dream House as Choose Your Own Adventure. The genre is the chapter's apparatus; the memoir's substance is always the same relationship, always the same house.

For you: you could format sections of your zine as the apparatus of different documents. Found Document as Autopsy Report. Found Document as Real Estate Listing.

Found Document as Recipe. Each section uses the apparatus's formatting conventions (headers, fields, stamps, signature lines) with content from the source or your own.

EXAMPLE – Maggie Nelson, *THE ARGONAUTS* (2015)

Nelson braids memoir, theory, and maternity notebook. Citations appear inline in the margins, italicized, with the cited author's name rather than footnote numbers. The apparatus of academic citation is imported into lyric prose. The reader is made aware, every page, that Nelson is thinking **with** others even in her most private moments.

Silence-Marking

Do not write the gap. Mark it.

WHY IT WORKS

The most disciplined operation available. When there is something you cannot say – about the source, about yourself, about the relation between them – silence-marking lets you acknowledge its presence without filling it. For material that exceeds what you can write, this is often the only honest move.

EXAMPLE – Layli Long Soldier, *WHEREAS* (2017)

Long Soldier's book is a response to the 2009 Congressional Resolution of Apology to Native Peoples – an apology signed by Obama that was never read aloud to Native peoples. The book uses the legal "Whereas" clause as its structural unit, then deliberately fails the form: Whereas clauses that refuse to conclude, that repeat, that cannot arrive at their resolution.

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STRUCTURE (Long Soldier-style silence marking):

WHEREAS she asked what it meant and I did not have an answer for her I
did not have an answer for her I did not have an answer

WHEREAS

[]

WHEREAS the translation of this word does not exist

The bracketed blank is the poem. The word that cannot be translated is marked but not translated. For your source: where is the gap you cannot fill? "The heartfelt moment of clarity" – the family does not tell us what was said. You could open that absence as a bracketed blank.

EXAMPLE – M. NourbeSe Philip, *ZONG!* (2008)

Philip takes the 500-word legal text of the 1781 *Gregson v. Gilbert* court decision – concerning the massacre of 150 enslaved Africans thrown overboard from the slave ship *Zong* for insurance purposes – and uses only those 500 words to build a 180-page book. The words are fragmented, scattered across white pages, with vast silences between them. The silence is the graveyard. The source is the legal record that did not grieve.

For you: consider a page that uses only the vital sign blocks from the source – numbers, units, timestamps – and nothing else. The medical record that did not grieve. Let the white space be the grief.

EXAMPLE – Caroline Bergvall, DRIFT (2014)

Bergvall works with Old English and medieval Scandinavian languages, often through what she calls "mistranslation." *Drift* weaves accounts of migrant deaths in the Mediterranean with the Old English *Seafarer* poem. Passages in Old English sit untranslated alongside contemporary testimony. The reader encounters what they cannot read.

The lesson: not all silence is visual. Silence can be linguistic – a passage the reader cannot decode. For your source: a medical Latin phrase left untranslated. A caretaker abbreviation you do not decipher. The refusal to explain is the mark.

VII.

Frame Disclosure

State what the source is, where it came from, and what you are doing with it.

WHY IT WORKS

Most of the time you do not want to disclose the frame – the mystery of the found document is doing work. But when the frame itself is the piece's subject, disclosure can be the entire opening gesture.

EXAMPLE – Bhanu Kapil, various prefaces

Kapil routinely opens books with direct statements: "I have been working on this for nine years." "I could not finish this book." "What follows is not a novel." The preface is part of the work – not a frame outside it.

For you, an opening page could read: This is a document I found in my Drive. I do not know whose family this is. I do not know how it got here. What follows is my reading of it. (I am not advising you to write that – I'm showing the move.)

EXAMPLE – Anne Boyer, *THE UNDYING* (2019)

Boyer's book about breast cancer opens by refusing the genre of cancer memoir – explicitly, by name. She names what the book will not be before telling you what it is. The frame disclosure becomes a negative definition: not a brave-patient memoir, not a celebration of medicine, not a comfort.

For you: your frame disclosure, if you use one, can be a list of what the piece is not. Not a eulogy. Not a confession. Not my father.

VIII.

On the Ethics of Found Text

The literary tradition of working with found material does not ask permission. It treats documents that enter circulation as material, subject to the same operations as any other source. But the absence of permission is not the absence of ethics.

Four principles recur across the field:

1. TRANSFORM.

The bar is not whether you quote but whether the work does something the source cannot do alone. Quotation is not transformation. Operations are. If your piece is a curated selection of the source's strong lines, you are a curator. If your operations reveal, reorder, erase, annotate, silence, or juxtapose in ways that change what the source says, you are a writer.

2. DO NOT IDENTIFY.

Names. Dates. Places. Searchable specifics. The source document includes at least one unusual searchable detail (a podcast name). That detail should not appear in your piece. Change it, omit it, blur it, or silence-mark it. The family in the source has the right to not be findable through your work.

3. DO NOT PROFIT ON THE UNALTERED SOURCE.

A self-published zine given to friends or posted to a portfolio is one thing. A book deal is another. If your work goes commercial, your transformation has to be decisive enough that the source is material, not product. This is less a legal threshold than an ethical one – the legal threshold is transformative use, which is meaningfully met by any real operation.

4. BE WILLING TO BE CHALLENGED.

If a member of the source family ever found your work, could you explain what you did and why? The answer does not have to be *they would approve*. The answer has to be *I can account for the operations I performed and the purpose they served*. Operations make the work defensible. Quotation does not.

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A final note on this specific source. You found it in your Google Drive. You did not put it there. You did not author it. You do not know the family. These facts are unusual and they are part of the piece's conditions. You are not obligated to investigate how the document arrived. You are also not obligated to ignore it. The fact of the document's arrival is itself material.

Whatever operations you perform, the piece that results is going to carry the residue of its origin. The mystery of the arrival is a kind of grace. Do not squander it by explaining too quickly, and do not exploit it by pretending the source is yours in a way it is not.

The source is not yours. The piece will be.

Further Reading

Primary works, in order of usefulness for this project.

ESSENTIAL – read before drafting

Anne Carson, *Nox* (2010)

→ The closest cousin to your form. Handle a copy if you can find one.

Maggie Nelson, *Bluets* (2009)

→ Numbered fragment form. Model for voice-braiding at the sentence level.

STRONG – read during drafting

Claudia Rankine, *Don't Let Me Be Lonely* (2004)

→ Multi-voice braiding with found media.

Bhanu Kapil, *Ban en Banlieue* (2015)

→ Failed-novel form; apparatus-as-voice.

Sarah Manguso, *Ongoingness* (2015)

→ Short fragment-memoir on the failure of the diary.

EXAMPLE BOOKS FOR SPECIFIC OPERATIONS

Mary Ruefle, *A Little White Shadow* (2006)

→ Erasure, correction-fluid method.

Srikanth Reddy, *Voyager* (2011)

→ Erasure of a politically-loaded source.

Jen Bervin, *Nets* (2004)

→ Selective-color erasure of Shakespeare's sonnets.

Jenny Boully, *The Body: An Essay* (2002)

→ Annotation without source text.

Layli Long Soldier, *Whereas* (2017)

→ Silence-marking; refused apology.

M. NourbeSe Philip, *Zong!* (2008)

→ Legal document fragmented into silence-poem.

ADJACENT / LATER

Carmen Maria Machado, *In the Dream House* (2019)

→ Genre-apparatus structure (Dream House as [X]).

Anne Boyer, *The Undying* (2019)

→ Refused-genre cancer memoir.

Renee Gladman, *Calamities* (2016)

→ Single-voice fragment prose.

Susan Howe, *Souls of the Labadie Tract* (2007)

→ Archival materials as poem source.

Caroline Bergvall, *Drift* (2014)

→ Mistranslation and medieval-source braiding.

Jenny Offill, *Dept. of Speculation* (2014)

→ Fragment-novel; small found-material units.

END OF DOCUMENT

This reference is part of the found_document_project workspace. It pairs with 05_OPERATIONS-TOOLKIT.md for the abstract theory of each move, and with the project plan for when to consult each entry. It is not exhaustive. The lineage is larger than any one reference file.